deter the stone-throwing mobs. When in 2017, the Indian Army warned that it wouldn't spare those disrupting their operations, the anti-India cries of the secessionists further garnered popular support. However, Islamabad's 'secret war' aimed at 'bleeding India by a thousand cuts' has been repeatedly exposed by several militants who have been captured or surrendered in the valley. And despite the insurgency having gone through many violent cycles and violent uprisings, politicians in New Delhi and Srinagar have failed to address the core issues of the Kashmiri people's grievances, while Pakistan's military intelligence agencies have continued to exploit this indecisiveness.

Peace and dialogue to restore their autonomy, perhaps even more than the freedom to lead a life of their choice, seems to be what most Kashmiris want. And recognising this, India's two former prime ministers, Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Dr Manmohan Singh, had both announced their intentions to offer that,[10] at the Sher-e-Kashmir stadium in Srinagar, during their respective tenures. Even Pakistan's military ruler, Gen. Musharraf, was willing to offer his '7 regions' proposal, a sort of halfway mark to the traditional Indo-Pak stand on Kashmir, as India ruled out a redrawing of the boundaries on the map. But whether it was a result of India's steady efforts at coercive diplomacy or the new fencing along the entire 740-kilometre LoC, India did see a drop-in infiltration from POK. Musharraf's promise of 'turning off' the tap of militants also worked for a while, with the announcement of a 'ceasefire' on the LoC and as Musharraf saw that his offer made little headway, a fractured ceasefire took its place.[11] Once he abdicated power, Pakistan's terror minders were back to their tried and trusted methods to keep Kashmir on the boil.

Since then, Pakistan's Army has reverted to providing artillery fire to those it trains and pushes across the LoC to keep the Kashmir boiling. This has resulted in fiery duels between the two armies on the LoC and a short but sharp conflict, known as the Kargil War that erupted in the summer of 1999, just after both the countries had become nuclear weapon states. Though the aim of Gen. Musharraf—then Pakistan's Army Chief—was to contest the sanctity of the LoC by putting regular and irregular soldiers on